

Polity Guide for the Kerygma Network of Churches

Telling the Story of Jesus Together

Preamble

“Behold, how good and how pleasant for brothers to dwell in true unity” (Ps 133:1)! While true unity is not found in any structure, surely Christians can promote a flourishing partnership in the gospel by thinking through the shape of their partnership. “Diligent plans lead only to profit, and everything that is hasty leads only to lack” (Prov 21:5). And while Scripture gives wide latitude to Christians who are shaping such partnerships, it certainly does lay down principles that repay study: God’s word is a lamp to our feet (Ps 119:105). This document provides a guide for organization and practice in churches of the Kerygma network.

Some of the intended benefits of this partnership are these: shared affirmation of and commitment to Christ-centered doctrine and ethics; a context for shared worship and mission; and a minimization of the risk of churches being left without leadership and care. The prescriptions of this document aim to promote such partnership and so to spur disciples of Christ on their way. However, they are not authoritative in the same way that the Scriptures are, and deviation from them is not sin (unless done in a spiteful way). Loyalty to Christ and to his gospel must take priority over every other loyalty. Mechanisms are provided both for individuals and for churches to leave a Kerygma church or the Kerygma network. Still, for as long as a person or congregation remains in Kerygma, it will surely be considerate and advantageous—part of doing things “decently and in order” (1 Cor 14:40)—if in the great majority of instances those who have agreed to them abide by them.

Individual Membership

Everyone from all ages who is in Christ is part of the people of God. But Scripture also describes the formation of local churches.

In theory, membership need not be something written down, but in the interests of clarity, accountability, and protection it seems advisable for churches to have a considered membership process.

Entrance into membership requires (1) completion of a (preferably brief) class orienting the prospective member to the basic teachings of Christianity and the overall meaning of membership, (2) prior baptism (preferably believers’ baptism by immersion, but if a prospective member was baptized otherwise and feels in his or her conscience that such was valid and meaningful, (re)baptism is not required), and (3) signature of two copies of the standardized Membership Agreement (see below), one for the member to keep and one for the church records (digitization of the file is permitted). The first requirement may be waived by a pastor if he has good reason to believe that the candidate is a well-grounded Christian (particularly if he knows them personally or is quite familiar with the church or denomination they come from). All three requirements are waived in the case of someone who is a member (and not under discipline) at another Kerygma church.

The Membership Agreement reads as follows. In becoming a member of this church, I affirm that I have believed in Jesus Christ—truly human and truly God, the Son of God—as my savior from the penalty that my sins deserve. I believe in one God, who is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. I aim to love, honor, and obey God. I also aim to love those around me, especially my family in Christ. I will try to be kind and courteous, even in disagreement. I agree to defer to church leadership and to the church documents.

Individuals may transfer their membership to another Kerygma church provided they are not under church discipline.

Individuals may rescind their church membership at any time by unambiguously communicating their withdrawal of membership to one or more of the pastors. This would preferably happen only after a

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period of prayer, discussion, and attempts to reconcile any differences that exist.

Members can only be disciplined by a formal vote, either by the pastors or by the congregation. They can only be received back into full fellowship by the vote of the local church that disciplined them (this requirement is waived if the disciplining church later dissolves, or if it leaves or is disciplined out of Kerygma).

A person under discipline in a Kerygma church is retained on the church records, but loses the privileges of voting in church meetings, of serving in church ministries, and of transferring her or his membership; (s)he is discouraged from partaking of the Lord's Table until the discipline is rescinded.

Discipline is to be administered when in the assessment of the church a member is unwilling to repent of sin. When the church assesses that the individual is repentant, he or she is to be received back as described above. On the principle that forgiven sin can still entail consequences, the pastors may, if they feel it necessary, place certain limits on the involvement of such individuals (e.g., forbidding involvement in children's ministry).

Church Practice

The essential mark of true discipleship is mutual love.

Baptism is to be administered to believers, and it is to be done by immersion unless in the judgment of the pastors a major hurdle (particularly a medical one) demands a different means. Administration does not need to be pastoral, and females in particular can request a female administration.

The Lord's Table is not restricted to members. It is restricted to believers, but the church will not enforce this except by way of warning. Communion does not need to be officiated by pastors.

The exercise of spiritual gifts is encouraged, so long as it is understood that (1) the directives found in 1 Cor 12-14 and 1 Thes 5 must be followed; (2) words of prophecy, exhortation, etc., are generally more descriptive than prescriptive; (3) the prophetic role is not a governing role; (4) not every believer has one of the more dramatic or public gifts, yet all believers are to be valued equally in this regard; and (5) no purported spiritual gift is really such (or else it has not been properly understood) if it contradicts scriptural teaching.

It is allowable to hold and (in appropriate venues and in charitable ways) to suggest diverse and nuanced views regarding the exact number and nature of continuing spiritual gifts (for example, some might classify as a word of exhortation what others would classify as a prophetic word), as long as (1) the principles of bibliology sketched in the Doctrinal Statement are upheld, (2) full cooperation is practiced with those in Kerygma who differ, and (3) the principles of the previous paragraph are followed.

For purposes of transparency, the church budget (though not necessarily sensitive financial reports, e.g. financial aid given to the needy) is to be made available for members' perusal.

Churches are encouraged but not required to include a provision in their by-laws requiring pastors, deacons, and/or people who will be involved in childcare ministries to undergo criminal background checks.

All pastors will be mandatory reporters.

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Pastors are encouraged but not required to hold occasional meetings with the church as a whole to offer updates and perspectives on the overall spiritual, missional, and financial situation the church faces.

It is strongly encouraged for one or more pastors to have (at least) annual check-ins with individuals or family units in the church, soliciting prayer requests that the pastors can devote themselves to, input on how any ministries the member(s) are involved in are going, and any concerns about the church as a whole the member(s) may have. Pastors are urged to take care to minimize the risk of members in general and deacon(esse)s in particular suffering burnout (though of course all members have a responsibility to communicate their needs with one another, since the pastors will always perceive these things).

Local Governance

Some general principles are these. (1) Where Scripture speaks to authority in the local church, it tends to speak of the pastors. (2) The Bible also appeals very frequently directly to congregations, as they have a crucial role to play and are by no means to be passive in the Christian walk. (3) Deference should be shown to leadership, and discourse should be respectful, but absolute obedience belongs only to God.

The pastors may restrict certain or all service positions in the church to members, and are encouraged to do so for sensitive and/or high-impact areas of service (e.g., children's ministry or small group leadership).

In recognition of the special role of the Apostles of the early Church, and reflecting the absence of an apostolic job description in 1 Timothy, apostles do not exist as an office with governing power.

A church may designate men or women as evangelists, and is allowed to pay them to enable concentrated evangelistic work, but the role of the evangelist is not a governing one.

The diaconate is a service role, not a governing role; so, while pastors may seek input and advice from them (and are encouraged to do so), deacons do not form an advisory board. Females may serve in the diaconate. (For the purposes of concision, "deacon" in this document can also mean "deaconess.") The pastors will decide whether deacons will focus attention on particular areas (e.g., mercy ministries, financial bookkeeping) or serve the church in general, unspecific ways.

In the New Testament the terms pastor, bishop, and elder, as these relate to church governance, seem to be synonymous. Within Kerygma, then, these terms are interchangeable and refer to one office.

Church governance rests on the pastor(s). Their decisions should be in accordance with (1) the present Polity Guide, (2) the Kerygma Doctrinal Statement, and (3) any additional by-laws a local church enacts (which should not contradict the first two items). Pastoral decisions are made either by a consensus view of the pastors or their vote (the latter is required in the case of discipline).

However, pastors may choose to put certain decisions (e.g., major financial decisions, selection of deacons) before the congregation for a vote of the members. These votes should be in-person (except under extraordinary circumstances, such as pandemics or wars) and not in absentia. Secret ballot is permitted. Members cannot mandate the holding of a vote, except for a vote on the question of rebuking or removing a pastor. In that scenario, the validity of the charges must be supported by at least two members. The membership can then vote to rebuke a pastor, to remove a pastor (which action also

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places him under discipline), exonerate the pastor, or to table discussion until a later point to give time for additional investigation, thought, and prayer. The rebuke or removal of a pastor should be communicated to the Regional Leader if possible.

A plurality of pastors at each church is strongly encouraged but not required. That pastors be paid decently (in due recognition of the size and needs of their families and the local cost of living) is encouraged but not required.

In order to satisfy State or other governmental requirements, churches may designate certain individuals as trustees, etc., but the implementation of such should not be done in a way that contradicts this Polity Guide.

Pastoral Ordination

The requirements for a man (the pastorate is for males—1 Tim 2:12) who desires the office of pastor and the attributes a pastor should maintain are laid out in 1 Tim 3:1-7 and Tit 1:6-9. It is to be noted that the qualifications are all matters of moral character except that he must show an aptitude for teaching (and arguably also Tit 1:9, though even this provision is perhaps more a question of Christian convictions than of academic proficiency). The provision in 1 Tim 3:2 is to be understood as calling for sexual, emotional, and overall faithfulness to his wife and not necessarily as banning those who have been divorced or who have married a previously divorced woman (and similarly in the case of deacons); Tit 1:6 is to be understood to say that his children, if he has any, are generally responsive, while they are young, to his fatherly leadership. In the process of evaluating a man's sense of pastoral calling, input from other Kerygma pastors, and especially from the Regional Leader, is encouraged. To serve pastorally in the Kerygma network does require assent to the authoritative documents. No one should be forced into pastoral ministry.

Ordination may be given by the vote of the pastors of the church at which the man is a member. A public laying on of hands is encouraged, as is the participation of other pastors who know the new pastor. A signed, dated document should be made, and a print of electronic copy of it should be made available to the Regional Leader.

A man who has been ordained at a church outside the denomination can have his ordination transferred to the denomination by the vote of the pastors of the Kerygma church at which the man is a member. The same mechanism can be used as appropriate to reaffirm the prior ordination of a man who, having earlier retired from ministry or transferred his ordination to a church outside the denomination, returns.

A pastor may transfer as a pastor (as opposed to simply as a member) to another Kerygma church at the discretion of the pastors of the receiving church, who may consult as necessary with the other pastors at the sending church and the relevant Regional Leader(s).

In the case of a church without a pastor, the Regional Leader takes over pastoral duties there in addition to his other responsibilities. He may at his discretion ordain one or more qualified members of that congregation. Alternatively or in addition, the Regional Leader may encourage (but cannot require) a Kerygma pastor to transfer from his current church to the one in need.

Loose Connectionalism

Scripture seems to describe the existence of numerous local churches, but not to describe the boundaries among and between them as absolute. The Bible furnishes examples of churches seeking a

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widely applicable decision (Acts 15), receiving outside direction as to their pastorates (Tit 1:5), and generally sharing in one another's needs and mission; yet the Bible neither frequently nor adamantly appeals to preset structures as a rigid means for resolving problems. The structure outlined here seeks to honor the spirit of this teaching: churches are not ultimately bound to any hierarchy or locked into a highly intricate polity, yet are called to cultivate tangible fellowship. For Kerygma, terms such as "denomination" and "network of churches" can be used interchangeably.

Each church keeps separate financial books and retains all assets.

Financial self-sufficiency of individual churches is to be sought as a norm, and churches cannot be compelled to give funds. Yet generosity, financial and otherwise, across churches is to be encouraged.

Churches may leave the denomination at any time, though preferably only after a reasonable effort has been made to resolve differences or address offenses.

Churches may be part of multiple networks, denominations, etc. as long as these (1) do not contradict what is written in the Doctrinal Statement; (2) are at least broadly compatible with the Polity Guide; and (3) the ultimate financial independence of each Kerygma church is preserved.

Regional Conferences

A Region is defined as being one of the following: one of the Reservations; one of the States apart from reservations; one of the Territories; or the District of Columbia. If churches in a region become numerous, a Regional Conference may vote on some proposal to divide itself into some number of Regions (for example, making certain counties or groups of counties separate Regions).

No governing body exists that is higher than a Region, and no one is empowered to speak authoritatively or definitively on behalf of the denomination as a whole.

A Regional Conference occurs approximately every six months. Attendance is strongly encouraged but not required for regional pastors and their wives, and suggested for others (especially deacons and aspiring leaders). It is to be an in-person event (excepting extraordinary circumstances). Includes singing; a public reading of Scripture; workshops; votes as necessary (concerning the Regional Leader; concerning churches joining or leaving the denomination; concerning proposals to reapportion the Region into multiple Regions; or concerning proposed amendments) by the regional pastors in attendance; and public discussion of proposed amendments. The Regional Leader (or in exceptional circumstances some other participant in the Regional Conference) will attempt to make other Regional Leaders elsewhere aware of any positive votes. The following conference will be normally given a tentative date at each conference, though in extraordinary circumstances the pastors of a region may work together to arrange a Regional Conference. A church alone in a region does not engage in a Regional Conference, but once at least two churches exist in a region, they should confer and set a date for their first conference.

Each Region will ordinarily have a Regional Leader. The Regional Leader is a pastor at a Kerygma church who (in addition to discharging his normal pastoral duties at his local church) is called on ordinarily to plan and to moderate the Regional Conference (see below); to make himself available within reason to pastors in his region for advice; and to care for a regional church without pastors until he ordains one or more men there or until a pastor transfers to that church. He holds 3-year, renewable terms. He is encouraged but not required to visit regional churches on occasion to see how things are going. He is

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chosen by a majority vote of the pastors present at the Regional Conference (in the event of an even split, the current leader retains his post if he is willing; if he is not, the role goes unfilled until the next conference, when a new vote is held). He can be removed from this post by a Regional Conference vote. He is automatically removed from the post if he ceases to be a pastor at his local church. If he is removed, or if he steps down for personal reasons or is otherwise unable to continue as a Regional Leader, the role will simply lie unfilled until the next Regional Conference, at which conference the pastors present will vote in a new regional leader.

Get-togethers of Kerygma churches for shared worship and mutual edification are strongly encouraged—particularly within regions, but also across regions.

Denominational Changes

Churches are added to the denomination in this way. The church, having arrived at an internal consensus of its wish to join Kerygma and its agreement with the Kerygma documents, makes its wishes known to one or more Kerygma pastors, who at their discretion may pass on the request to the relevant Regional Conference. A majority vote by the Regional Conference (either at the meeting at which the issue is raised; or at a future conference if the issue is tabled, or voted down but then revisited) then grants the church entrance into the Region. The first two churches in a new region are accepted into the denomination by written assent from some Regional Leader (or, if there are none, the vote of a Kerygma church).

Having joined Kerygma, a church should make whatever changes are necessary to bring its governing documents and practices into line with this Polity Guide and the Kerygma Doctrinal Statement within a reasonable period of time (normally, before participating as a Kerygma church in a Regional Conference). If some or all of the existing leadership of the church is not ordained (e.g., lay elders, or a board of deacons), those men who will be taking on the role of pastor outlined in this document can choose whether to be formally ordained (optionally with the participation of the Regional Leader) or to consider their prior role as a *de facto* ordination.

Churches can be disciplined out of the denomination—with a recorded statement as to the rationale (e.g., persistent sin or persistent failure to communicate with the region)—with a majority vote of the pastors present at the relevant Regional Conference.

In recognition of the possibility that over time many or all of the churches of a region would develop distinctive liturgical emphases or doctrinal stances, the following mechanism exists: if the majority of the churches of a region so vote, a region of churches can leave the denomination *en masse* so that this group of churches can readily reorganize, retaining its inner unity. A stipulation: individual churches may opt out of such a departure, indicating such either at the outset or communicating their decision to the relevant leaders in Kerygma and in the new fellowship of churches within a year of the departure vote.

Changes either to the Polity Guide or to the Kerygma Doctrinal Statement should adhere to the following procedure. (1) A Kerygma church will decide to forward a proposed amendment to their Regional Leader. (2) The Regional Leader will present the proposal at the next Regional Assembly. (3) At the Regional Assembly following that, the Regional Assembly will vote. In the event of a positive vote, (4) the Regional Leader will notify the other Regional Leaders, who will raise the proposal at their next assemblies and vote at the assembly following that. (5) If within three years of the first regional vote to accept the proposal a majority of regions vote positively, then the change takes effect; if not, the proposal is rejected, and the process would be to start over again if in the future a church wishes to propose it

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anew. In the event of changes to the provisions concerning the financial independence of each church and/or the freedom of churches to leave the network, these changes will not take effect for a full year, during which time churches may leave the network if they think it best.

Closing

A final and crucial exhortation: cultivating good communication skills—a listening ear and kind words—will be essential in the maintenance of effective partnership. Among believers, agreement may not always be full, but love must be fervent. The fellowship of the Spirit must be allowed to overrule both tribalism and individualism. May the God of all perfections be glorified through the best efforts of his imperfect people to honor his name and spread his fame.